

EMPOWERING WOMEN THROUGH EDUCATION

S. Neelima, CEO of Anurag University, has a clear and holistic vision of what needs to be done to make her educational institution the best place for women.

Can you describe your journey to becoming the CEO of Anurag University?

I completed my B.Tech from JNTU, Hyderabad, and M.Tech from Osmania University, Hyderabad. I served as an engineer in Transco for over two and a half decades. Subsequently, I assumed the role of Managing Trustee of the Gayathri Educational and Cultural Trust, which oversees the Anurag Group. Actively participating in the day-to-day activities of the Anurag Group for the last two decades, I took over the leadership role in 2014. I'd like to share the journey of Anurag University as well. We started in 1998 as an undergraduate college and in 2002 added an engineering college. Later we added a college of pharmacy, and PG college. We integrated them in 2010 under the name of Anurag Group of Institutions, affiliated to JNTU. In 2011 we became autonomous institutions. In 2020, we transformed into Anurag University and I became the CEO.

What were the challenges and stand-out moments along the journey?

As a teaching institution our first focus was to ensure our students get good jobs. Our other target was to secure prestigious accreditations like NAAC and NBA and rankings like NIRF. These were our challenges over the years, and we have surmounted them. Our students and faculty achieving their goals are also memorable events in our journey. After transforming into a University in 2020, our current target is to evolve into a teaching-cum-research institute.

What steps has Anurag University taken to promote gender equality?

At Anurag University, we are extremely sensitive to gender issues, and take care of the well-being and growth of both our students and faculty, especially women. When parents and students choose Anurag University, their main objective is a good education. The second-most important concern, especially for girls, is safety and security, especially since 40 percent of our students are girls and they are from rural areas living far away from their parents.

For our girl students, we offer sessions on mental health as well as take care of their health and hygiene concerns. We have a medical college with the best doctors and psychiatrists available. There are sanitary vending machines in every toilet as well as incinerators for sustainable disposal. We provide paid maternity leave to our women faculty and allow flexibility for leaves.

As a woman leader in the education space, what is your vision for empowering women?

Education is a tool for all human beings, irrespective of gender, to improve their lives. If we are well educated, we can understand societal issues better. Being in a leadership role in an educational institution, I'm always there to support girl students in any issues they may face in their educational pursuits. As a woman, I understand their concerns, and my approach is to help them to grow.

What is the significance of Women's Day for you?

While we celebrate Women's Day once a year, I believe whatever deliberations and discussions we have on that day should be implemented throughout the year like maintaining gender equality and empowerment of women. The Women's Day theme for current year, Invest in Women : accelerate progress, will well understood and followed in a true spirit. The investment in women helps in family and community development which leads to economic growth of the society. As a women leader I will strive to take care of the well-being of girl students and women faculty for their growth.

What are your goals and aspirations for Anurag University?

Our main stakeholders are students, faculty and the industry, their needs and requirements are met in a smarter way by following our benchmarks in our education field. We would like our students to get better jobs in best and product companies. We want our faculty to excel through projects, consultancy and getting their research published in top-notch journals. We are also trying to improve our present rankings. At the same time, we want to inculcate a culture of innovation among students. We have created a startup culture from the first year itself in the engineering departments, where our students are involved in engineering explorations subjects and design thinking activities. We want to add more disciplines and take a collaborative multidisciplinary approach to make it as a best teaching cum research institution.